

No Longer a Slave but a Son

In Galatians, I have been trying to wrap up this section on Abraham's covenant, the promise God made to Abraham, and the law that was added four hundred and thirty years later.

The promise God made to Abraham was fulfilled in our adoption, when you and I became sons and daughters of God. Paul's argument with the Galatians is this: now that you have become a son, why would you go back into bondage under the elements of the world, observing seasons and times?

Whether Jew or Gentile, you were a servant to sin. You had the nature of sin.

There is a difference between being saved and being born again. A saved person before the resurrection was waiting on the promise of the new birth. They had adhered to whatever God required in their covenant and dispensation to inherit the promise, but they were waiting for the promise to be fulfilled.

We used to say, "I am a covenant man," and also, "I am a son of God." Well, which are you? I was a covenant man waiting on the promise, but the promise came. I was born again and became a son of God.

Now that I have inherited the promise, I am a son of God with a new nature and full inheritance.

Under Jewish law, the oldest male inherited the fortune of the father. In the family of God, Jesus is the firstborn from the dead among many brethren. He is the oldest living Brother in the body of Christ.

He inherited the Father's fortune, then turned around and made you a joint heir with Himself.

Now I approach God on the basis of sonship. I used to stand outside the gates and yell about my rights. Now I walk in, open the refrigerator, and sit down.

Faith begins to change when you understand sonship. Outside the promises, you are always trying to attain. But a son is part of the family.

Faith can become part of your nature. God does not merely have love. He is love. All love had to come from somewhere. Likewise, God does not merely have faith as something outside Himself. He is the One who stands behind His word.

The closer your nature is transformed toward the Father, the more faith becomes like a first nature. Worry is second nature from the flesh. Faith becomes the knowing confidence of the new nature.

We have often been taught that God stood on the edge of the universe, filled His words with faith, and spoke the worlds into existence. But after a word is spoken, Someone still has to watch over it to perform it.

Your words are not mindless forces operating on their own. When you command a devil to come out, the devil does not leave because your volume was correct. Someone must make him come out.

Jesus said:

"If I with the finger of God cast out devils,
no doubt the kingdom of God is come upon you."

The finger of God is the Holy Spirit. When you command a devil and it comes out, it is because the kingdom of God has come, and the Holy Spirit is enforcing the command.

Hebrews 11 is not saying God framed the cosmos by filling words with faith as though words were independent powers. It says the ages and generations were framed by the Word of God, so the things seen in those generations came from things not seen.

Noah's ark, the flood, Moses delivering Israel, Abraham's line: those things appeared in history because a hidden word and faith in a man framed a generation.

As a family member, you need to know that faith can become part of your nature. You can trust God before doubt gets a chance.

The church keeps slipping into forms of legalism because we have not fully understood who we are and what we became when we were born again. Even with righteousness teaching and "in Him" teaching, we still have not always understood the new birth.

Paul contends with the Galatians because they are trying to go back under the law. He says, "You want to go back under the law? I came out from under it. Who has bewitched you?"

Romans says we now serve in newness of spirit. When we were in the flesh, the motions of sin which were by the law worked in our members to bring forth death. But we were set free from the law by the body of Christ so we could serve in the newness of spirit, the new nature He made us in the new birth.

Galatians 3:18-19 says:

"For if the inheritance be of the law,
it is no more of promise:
but God gave it to Abraham by promise.
Wherefore then serveth the law?
It was added because of transgressions,
till the seed should come to whom the promise was made."

Many commentaries say the phrase "ordained by angels in the hand of a mediator" refers to the law given through Moses. But if you leave out the King James italicized additions, the verse points back to the promise:

The law was added because of transgressions until the Seed should come, to whom the promise was made, ordained by angels in the hand of a mediator.

The promise to Abraham was ordained through a mediator, and that mediator was Abraham. A mediator is not a mediator of one, yet God is one. Abraham mediated between two parties in the Godhead: the Father and the promised Seed, Christ.

The Word had to become flesh. God needed a man through whom He could bring that covenant line into the earth. Abraham mediated the covenant of flesh through which the Son would come.

Galatians 3:21-26 says:

"Is the law then against the promises of God?
God forbid:
for if there had been a law given which could have given life,
verily righteousness should have been by the law.
But the scripture hath concluded all under sin,
that the promise by faith of Jesus Christ might be given to them that believe.
But before faith came,
we were kept under the law,
shut up unto the faith which should afterwards be revealed.
Wherefore the law was our schoolmaster to bring us unto Christ,
that we might be justified by faith.
But after that faith is come,
we are no longer under a schoolmaster.
For ye are all the children of God by faith in Christ Jesus."

The law was a schoolmaster, a tutor and governor, until Christ came. But after faith came, we were no longer under that schoolmaster.

If you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's seed and heirs according to the promise. You have already inherited.

Practically speaking, I no longer live as a man standing outside the gate yelling covenant claims. I had a covenant, and that covenant caused me to be adopted. That covenant was fulfilled when Jesus rose from the dead, was quickened in His spirit, and made the new birth available.

Thank God for the covenant with Abraham. But if you are Christ's, you are Abraham's seed and have inherited according to the promise.

A son approaches differently. He does not need pressure, manipulation, or legalism to receive from his father.

If legalism worked, it would work both directions. Every legalistic dollar a preacher got from you would bring a legalistic hundred dollars back. But legalism tends to work better for the person demanding it than for the person giving it.

God loves a cheerful giver. He does not want giving produced by necessity, pressure, fear, or manipulation. If you must be pressured, threatened, or emotionally cornered to give, you do not yet understand inheritance.

He has made you a son and a daughter. You are a joint heir with Jesus, now and in the ages to come.

Galatians 4:1-2 says:

"Now I say, That the heir,
as long as he is a child,
differeth nothing from a servant,
though he be lord of all;
But is under tutors and governors
until the time appointed of the father."

The Holy Spirit told me to look at the word "servant." It is the word for slave.

Paul is speaking of the Jew who held the promise in the natural. Israel held the promise to Abraham and his Seed, Christ. Yet as long as that promise had not been fulfilled, they were no different than the Gentile slave to sin, even though they stood to inherit.

They were spiritually dead like everyone else. Old Testament saints were saved and waiting on the promise, but they still had to be born again when the promise was fulfilled. They waited in Abraham's bosom until the born-again experience was available.

The Jew held the promise, but without the new birth he could not enter the inheritance in fullness.

Galatians 4:3-7 says:

"Even so we, when we were children,
were in bondage under the elements of the world:
But when the fulness of the time was come,
God sent forth his Son,
made of a woman,
made under the law,
To redeem them that were under the law,
that we might receive the adoption of sons.
And because ye are sons,
God hath sent forth the Spirit of his Son into your hearts,
crying, Abba, Father.
Wherefore thou art no more a servant,
but a son;
and if a son, then an heir of God through Christ."

The Spirit of His Son is not the Holy Spirit in this verse. The Holy Spirit is the third Person of the Godhead. The Spirit of His Son refers to the new nature, the same kind of life Jesus received in His humanity when He was quickened from death to life.

I used to have the spirit of the first man Adam. I did not have Adam's personal human spirit; I had my own spirit, but I inherited spiritual death from him.

Now I have the Spirit of Christ. I do not have Jesus' personal human spirit; He has His own. But the same quickening that happened to Him happened to me. That is when I inherited sonship and was adopted by God.

I am no longer a slave. I am a son of God.

John 8:31-32 says:

"If ye continue in my word,
then are ye my disciples indeed;
And ye shall know the truth,
and the truth shall make you free."

We use those verses correctly as a branch: the more Word you understand, the more revelation and transformation you receive. But the root meaning in context is the new birth. Jesus is speaking to Jews who believed on Him. If they continued in His word, they would follow Him into the truth of who He was and be made free from spiritual death.

They answered:

"We be Abraham's seed,
and were never in bondage to any man:
how sayest thou, Ye shall be made free?"

Jesus answered:

"Whosoever committeth sin is the servant of sin.
And the servant abideth not in the house for ever:
but the Son abideth ever.
If the Son therefore shall make you free,
ye shall be free indeed."

He was telling Abraham's natural seed that they were not free from sin merely because they held the promise. The servant of sin cannot remain in the house forever. The Son makes you free by making you a son.

Galatians 4 says Jesus was made of a woman and made under the law. Because He was born under the law, He was obligated to fulfill it.

He could fulfill it because He was the first Man in four thousand years to be born spiritually alive. The curse of the law was that spiritually dead men could not keep it.

Second Corinthians 3 calls the law engraved on stones the ministration of death. What was engraved on stones? The Ten Commandments.

The commandments described the nature of God, but a spiritually dead man could not keep them. The law functioned as schoolmaster, beating into Israel the knowledge that they could not inherit in that state.

Jesus came, born under the law, able to fulfill it to the last detail. Then He stepped into the shoes of every Jew who could not keep it, took the curse of the law, hung on a tree, and died under that penalty so they could receive the adoption of sons.

Galatians 4:8-10 says:

"Howbeit then, when ye knew not God,
ye did service unto them which by nature are no gods.
But now, after that ye have known God,
or rather are known of God,
how turn ye again to the weak and beggarly elements,
whereunto ye desire again to be in bondage?
Ye observe days, and months, and times, and years."

Paul takes it a step further: now that you have known God, or rather are known of God.

God knew Israel as servants under promise, but they could not know Him by nature until the new birth. Now, in Christ, they know God through the new nature, and God knows them as sons written into His will.

Why turn back to weak and beggarly elements? Why return to bondage under days, months, times, and years after becoming sons and daughters of God?

You are no longer a slave. You are a son, and if a son, then an heir of God through Christ.